



**Iron Minds**

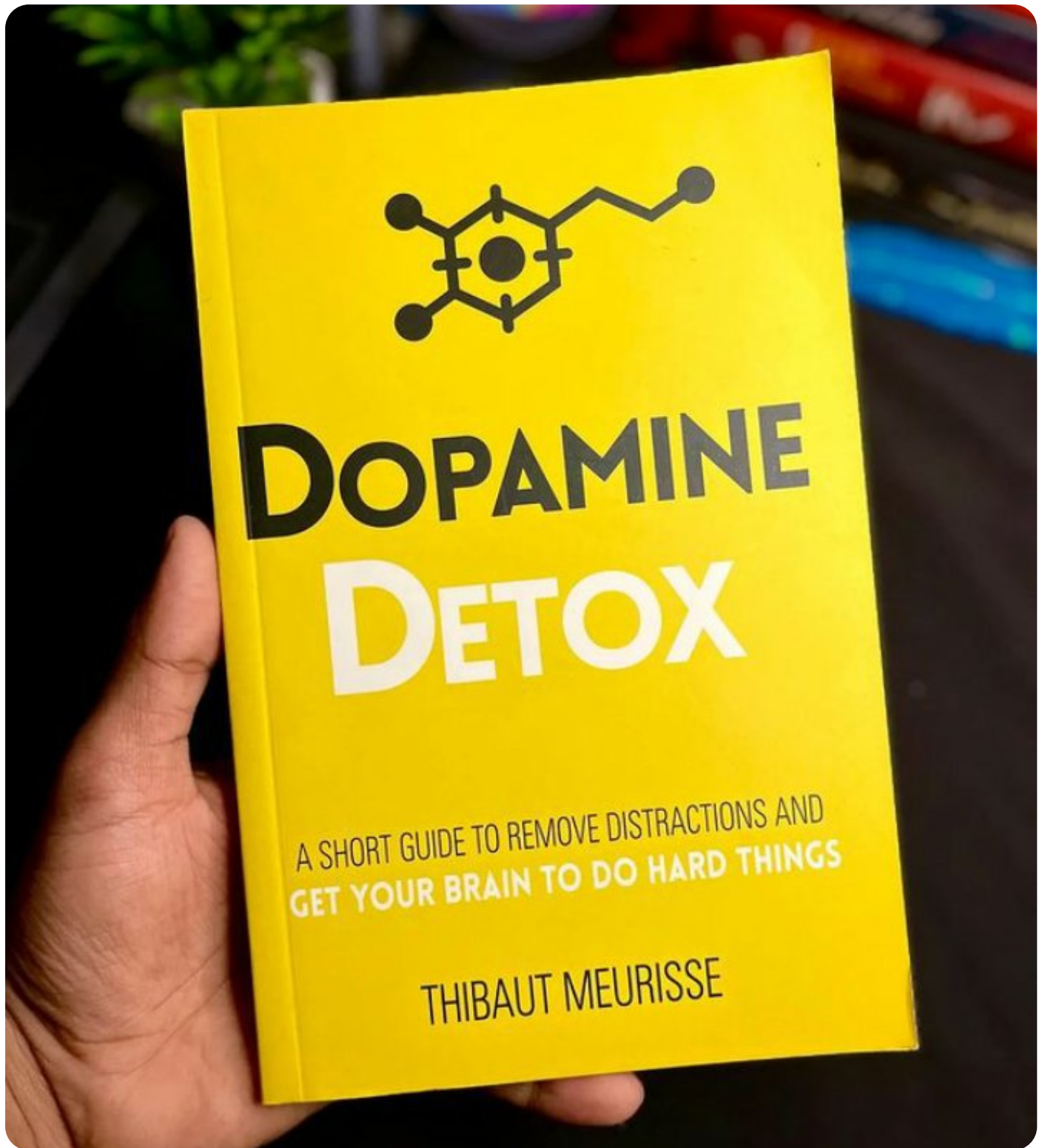
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## 9 Lessons From The Book "Dopamine Detox":

- Thread -



1.

You've probably heard about dopamine before and have at least a vague idea of what it is. In this section, we'll briefly define dopamine and describe the role it plays.

Dopamine is a neurotransmitter which makes us anticipate rewards such as having sexual relationships or eating nourishing food. Dopamine gives us the desire to take action to earn the exciting reward that's waiting for us. It is the force that makes us act. As such, it is a very useful neurotransmitter that has helped us survive and reproduce—and probably one of the main reasons you and I exist today.

Contrary to what many people believe, dopamine is not a pleasure chemical. Simply because an event triggers the release of dopamine doesn't mean it is something we like or get pleasure from. In fact, when you pay close attention, you'll notice that as soon as you obtain the expected reward, you'll often feel empty and unfulfilled.

The truth is that no amount of stimulation will ever bring you the sense of fulfillment you're seeking. Yet, many of us are constantly

- What other activity do I need to avoid in order to help me increase my focus most significantly?

Keep asking yourself this question, until you're happy with your answers.

Once you have completed your list, put it on your desk or somewhere you will see it. It will act as a good reminder of the activities you must avoid.

### Step #2. Add friction

Generally speaking, the harder something is to access, the less likely you are to do it and vice-versa. This is why you must redesign your environment to make undesirable behaviors more difficult to engage in while making more desirable behaviors easier to conduct.

Look at the habits or activities you want to eliminate and ask yourself how you could add friction—the more friction, the better. For instance:

- If your phone is your biggest distraction, remove all notifications or put it on airplane mode. Or, even better, switch it off and put it in a separate room.
- If Facebook is your biggest distraction, remove as many notifications as you can and/or use applications such as Newsfeed Eradicator (a Google Chrome extension).
- If you spend hours watching YouTube videos, install DF Tube on your Google Chrome navigator, or find a similar app for your internet browser. This will remove all the suggestions and notifications. Then, only watch videos that serve a specific purpose.

Remember, excitement isn't fulfillment. Excitement can be fun, but make sure you work on developing an inner sense of peace and a heightened state of focus. This is much more likely to bring you fulfillment in the long run.

If you want to learn how to use your time both effectively and meaningfully in greater depth, read Book 8 in my *Mastery Series*, *Master Your Time*.

#### Trick #4—you're missing out

Checking emails or news every thirty minutes gives you the illusion of having some control over your environment. You don't want to miss an urgent email or the latest breaking news, right?

But do you always need to reply to emails right away? Do you really have to check the latest news regularly?

This way of thinking results from the fear of missing out. And this fear reflects a scarcity mindset, which is based on the idea that there might be a limited number of opportunities available to you. As such, you should seize each opportunity while you still can, shouldn't you? But opportunities are everywhere. There will always be more in the future. Thus, if you "miss" a piece of news, were unable to join a particular event, or failed to watch your favorite YouTuber's last live video, it's okay. Sure, I wouldn't recommend you miss the birth of your children or the wedding of your brother or sister, but for most events, it doesn't matter.

## PART IV

# A THREE-STEP METHOD FOR A SUCCESSFUL DETOX

In this section, we'll go over a simple three-step method to help you perform a successful dopamine detox.

### Step #1. Identify your biggest distractions

The first step to implementing an effective dopamine detox is to identify your biggest temptations and distractions. To do so, take a pen and a sheet of paper (or use your action guide), and create two columns, "Cans" and "Can'ts".

In the first column write down all the activities you will allow yourself to engage in. For instance, it might be going for a walk, journaling, working on a project, or reading books. In the second column, write down all the things you must avoid doing during your dopamine detox. For instance, it might be watching YouTube, checking your emails, or using social media.

To help you do this, ask yourself the following questions:

- If I stopped doing only one thing, which one would

making progress toward your biggest goals each day. However, the problem is that you're often anything but calm and focused. Instead, you're rushing through your day, jumping from one task to the next. You tend to run in circles like a hamster in a wheel, yet you never seem to complete your work. You let interruptions kill your focus and you waste hours checking your emails, visiting social media sites or watching one "educational" video after another.

It often starts first thing in the morning when you grab your phone. Then, it continues when you check your emails. But it doesn't stop there. You then decide to visit social media sites for "a few minutes". By that time, emails, notifications, and likes will have already triggered the release of dopamine into your system. In short, you've become overstimulated.

Now that you've received your dose of stimulation, you can work, right? But what happens when you sit at your desk to work on an important project? Does it come easy, or do you feel like doing everything else *but* working? Perhaps you tell yourself you can work on that particular task later. Perhaps you suddenly fancy another cup of coffee or perhaps you just remembered the email you need to answer.

Your work can wait—or so you think.

As a result, you're back in

- Look at your list of "Can'ts". Next to each of them, write down specific things you could do to *add* friction.
- Then, look at your list of "Cans" and write down things you could do to *eliminate* friction.

Remember, your mind is lazy. Use this to your advantage.

### Step #3 Start first thing in the morning

The third and final step is simply to get started. I recommend you start first thing in the morning before becoming overly stimulated. I've noticed that if I check my phone or access the internet upon waking up, I will probably become distracted.

I also recommend you create a morning routine to help you start your day on a positive note and with a strong focus. Over the long term, a simple morning routine can make a massive difference in your life.

What about you? What's the first thing you do when you wake up? Does this help you remain calm and focused, or does it lead you to feel overstimulated and result in procrastination?

To establish your morning routine, write down two or three simple things you could do each morning. You'll use these activities to kickstart your dopamine detox—and, hopefully, you will stick to the routine over the long term. Remember that the routine should deepen your focus rather than distract you.

as below:

- The 48-hour complete dopamine detox.
- The 24-hour dopamine detox.
- The partial dopamine detox.

Let's describe each process in greater depth and discuss how they work.

### **The 48-hour complete dopamine detox**

This is the most demanding type of dopamine detox. The premise is simple:

You must eliminate most or all sources of external stimulation for a total of 48 hours. Doing so will help you reduce your overall level of stimulation and revert to your natural state. You will feel much calmer and find it easier to focus on any specific important task.

By "eliminating all external sources of stimulation", I mean you need to remove the following things from your life for 48 hours:

- Drug/alcohol consumption,
- Exercising,
- Internet,
- Movies,
- Music (except perhaps for relaxation music),
- Phone,
- Social media,

"trance". Instead, your mind encourages you to embrace it and seek even more stimulation. After all, we have to enjoy life, right?

In this section, let's go over four tricks your mind plays on you to keep you overstimulated.

#### Trick #1—returning to work is easy

The first trick your mind will play on you is to pretend that returning to work will be easy. It will try to convince you that you can start work whenever you choose, that you're in control of your actions. But this couldn't be further from the truth. In most cases, you won't be able to get back to work for hours. You might even find yourself postponing your key tasks until the next day.

The bottom line is, once you're overstimulated, you'll find it difficult to go back to work. I can't count how many times I told myself I would start writing later.

It never happens.

Therefore, if you catch yourself thinking you're in control of your actions and can return to work whenever you want, watch out!

#### Trick #2—you can do it later

Another trick your mind will use is to tell you that you can do your task later. It will convince you there is plenty of time in the afternoon or that you can always do it tomorrow, next week or next month. However, if you don't fight back, putting things off will become a habit. And five years from now, you'll

- Video games.

Each of the above activities stimulates you, some more than others. Now, you might wonder:

If I eliminate these distractions, what should I be doing instead?

Here are some suggestions:

- Going for a contemplative walk,
- Journaling,
- Meditating/relaxing,
- Practicing awareness exercises,
- Reading (except stimulating read perhaps), and
- Stretching exercises.

As you can see, the 48-hour dopamine detox is intensive and might appear rather drastic. But it could be even more extreme. One of my friends, Nils, attended a Vipassana retreat, which is a 10-day meditation retreat. During the ten days, the participants are required to:

- Maintain complete silence (and have no gesture or eye

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